HOMEPAGE

Slogan:
For Nepalese Indigenous Women,
By Nepalese Indigenous Women

Who we are:
Indigenous Women Legal Awareness Group (INWOLAG) is a non-governmental, non-profit, and non-political organisation established on 19 August 2000 (3 Bhadra 2057 B.S.) by a group of seven Indigenous women lawyers committed to protecting and promoting the dignity, rights, and well-being of Indigenous communities, particularly women, in Nepal.

INWOLAG was established for Indigenous women and girls, recognising the fact that national laws and legal systems often overlooked the distinct social, cultural, and linguistic traditions of Indigenous communities.

Positioning itself as a trailblazing Indigenous women's rights organization, our vision is to build an equitable society free from discrimination and violence, where the collective rights of indigenous communities are recognised and respected.

What we do:
INWOLAG focuses on advancing Indigenous women's rights and access to justice through a holistic approach combining legal aid, advocacy, awareness, research, and empowerment.

Our core areas of work include:
• Legal Aid (Access to Justice)
• Indigenous Collective Rights
• Gender Just Climate
• Research and Study

Why we do:
INWOLAG's objectives stems from a deep commitment to justice, equity, and empowerment for Indigenous women and communities long marginalised by Nepal's legal and socio-political structures.

We aim to:
• Increase access to justice for Indigenous women and girls.

• Eliminate discrimination, exploitation, and violence through awareness and advocacy.
• Uphold Indigenous collecting rights, including land, resources, and traditional knowledge.
• Support community resilience against structural inequalities, gender-based violence, and climate and development impacts.
• Promote Indigenous women's leadership and representation in decision-making processes.

Where we have worked:

INWOLAG has extended its work across 40 districts in all seven provinces of Nepal, touching upon regions with a high concentration of Indigenous populations and significant human rights challenges.

(Map Photo)

OUR PARTNERS (Logos in drive):
https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1_HtyuQ2AK6y5Hx-5oeHGilhuJ-GhVHnF

NFDIN
TEWA
FWLD
Mamacash
FIMI
RRI
NGO Forum on ADB
Coalition for Human Rights in Development
AIPP
Women's Fund Asia (WFA)
Global Greengrants Fund (GGF)
Global Alliance for Green and Gender Action (GAGGA)

TEAM

Core Team (YET TO UPDATED)

- Adv. Indira Kumari Shreesh (Founder/ Chairperson)
  Indira Kumari Shreesh is a practicing lawyer in CLRC (Continental legal research center), Lalitpur and has been practising for more than 22 years. She is one of the founding members of INWOLAG. She has been a legal fellow of SAWF since 2013. As an activist, she has been working extensively in the field of providing legal aid to women and children, especially of indigenous and marginal communities.

- Adv. Uma Tamang (Founder/ Vice Chairperson)
  UmaTamang is the founding board member of INWOLAG. She has completed her Proficiency Certificate Level and bachelor of law study from Nepal law campus and masters in sociology from Tri Chandra campus. She is also active in Maiti Nepal. She has a lot of experience in legal counseling and advocacy for trafficked women. She has been active in the field of law for a very long time.

- Adv. Kaushila Rai (Founder/ General Secretary)
  Kaushila Rai is a founding member of INWOLAG. She is an indigenous rights activist and advocate. She has her own law firm where she provides legal services. She has completed her master's degree in law from Purbanchal University. She has been practicing law regarding domestic violence, indigenous women's rights, gender rights for more than 22 years.
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- Adv. Ritu Thapa Magar (Founder/ Treasurer)

  Adv Ritu Thapa is an Indigenous lawyer, human rights advocate, and trainer with over two decades of experience in advancing the rights of Indigenous Peoples, particularly women and girls in Nepal. She is a founding member and Treasurer of the Indigenous Women Legal Awareness Group (IWNOLAG), where she provides free legal aid, leads advocacy initiatives, and supports strategic litigation for marginalized communities.

  Her work focuses on strengthening access to justice, addressing violence against women (VAW), and advancing Indigenous Peoples' rights, including Free, Prior, and Informed Consent (FPIC), land rights, and equitable development. She has been actively engaged in legal advocacy for Indigenous communities affected by large-scale development projects, including the Tanahu Hydropower Project. She also has extensive experience working on conservation and protected areas, with a focus on Indigenous Peoples' rights, Indigenous Women Human Rights Defenders, and access to justice in national park contexts.
  Advocate Thapa holds a Master's degree in Law from the University of Pune and a Master's in Indigenous Education and Development from Kathmandu University. She is an alumna of the Human Rights Advocates Program (HRAP) and Indigenous Studies at Columbia University, New York, and has participated in international leadership programs, including the East-West Center's Asia Pacific Leadership Program.
  She has contributed to research, publications, and policy advocacy on issues such as gender-based violence, climate change, and Indigenous women's rights. She was

recognized as the second top-performing woman in the Advocate License Examination by the Nepal Bar Council and is a recipient of the Nainoa Thompson Award from the East-West Center, University of Hawaii. .
Advocate Thapa continues to engage in national and international platforms to promote inclusive, accountable, and rights-based approaches to justice and development.

- Adv. Mon Kumari Rai (Board Member)
  Mon Kumari Rai has completed Bachelor in Law from Tribhuvan University, Nepal. She is one of the serving board members of INWOLAG. She has been actively working and an activist for promoting rights of women and indigenous community through advocacy, free legal aid and training. She engages in regular awareness programs centered around indigenous women regarding their rights and gender violence.

- Adv. Jayanti Rai (Board Member)

- Adv. Rita Sherpa (Board Member)

Advisory Council:

- Adv. Sarada Subba (Founder)
  Sarada Subba is the founding chairperson of INWOLAG. She is a human right lawyer. She has done her Masters in Human Right and Gender Justice from KSL. She has been actively working as an activist for promoting rights of women and indigenous community through advocacy, free legal aid and training. She actively advises the board on their activities and engages in the organization's programs.

- Adv. Kshatra Kumari Gurung (Founder)

- Adv. Basundhara Thapa (Founder)

- Yasokanti Bhattachan

Focal Person:

- Gita Thapa (Tanahu)

- Punam Shrestha (Banke)

- Kamala Bahik (Rupandehi)

- Anita Rai (Koshi)

- Phulmati Mahato (Kanchanpur)

ABOUT US

Mission

To create an egalitarian and prospective society where there is no domination and discrimination based on race, caste, ethnicity, language, religion, culture, gender, class, and region.

Vision

To create a condition where indigenous women are recognized, and the language and culture of indigenous peoples are respected.

Objectives

- To increase access to justice to indigenous women and children by providing legal aid service, legal counseling, legal advocacy and mediation to indigenous women and children to secure their legal and human rights.
- To conduct investigation, study, and legal research on various issues of indigenous peoples with a focus on indigenous women and children, including international laws relating to indigenous women and children.
- To advocate for the socioeconomic, cultural, educational, and intellectual agenda and issues of indigenous women and children.
- To raise legal awareness among indigenous peoples and marginalized communities to eliminate all forms of discrimination, exploitation, and violence against indigenous women and children through publication, partnering media, conducting trainings, workshops, interaction, seminars, symposia, dialogues and talk programs on indigenous women's and children's issues.
- To monitor incidences of human rights violation, with a focus on violence against indigenous women and children, and carry out field investigation, if necessary.
- To work for effective implementation of international standards of human rights with a focus on The United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP), Convention 169 – Indigenous and Tribal Peoples Convention, 1989 and Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW).
- To work for political rights of indigenous women especially on the representation of indigenous women at various levels of state from federal to local level.

THEMATIC WORKS

- **LEGAL AID (ACCESS TO JUSTICE)**

INWOLAG provides legal awareness, counseling, litigation, and psychosocial services to Indigenous women survivors of violence and rights violations, all for free. As a leading advocate for Indigenous women's rights, we bridge access to justice and empowerment at both the local and national levels.

Activities/ Projects:

- **INDIGENOUS COLLECTIVE RIGHTS**

INWOLAG promotes the collective ownership, identity, and self-determination of Indigenous communities by safeguarding their ancestral lands, cultures, and traditions.
With a strong emphasis on the principle of Free, Prior and Informed Consent (FPIC), we ensure that Indigenous peoples have the right to make decisions about their lands, territories, and resources before any development or policy is implemented.

Activities/ Projects:

- **GENDER JUSTICE CLIMATE**

INWOLAG provides livelihood training programs for Indigenous women to help them mitigate and adapt to the impacts of climate change. These trainings equip women with practical skills and sustainable practices that enhance both environmental resilience and economic independence.

Activities/ Projects:

- **RESEARCH AND PUBLICATIONS**

Research and documentation have remained central to INWOLAG's strategy of evidence-based lobby and advocacy. Over the duration of 25 years, the organisation led multiple research projects that documented the impacts of development projects on Indigenous Peoples, amplified Indigenous women's voices, and provided data for rights-based policymaking.

- Women & Rivers (Beyond Borders): 2025

- Beyond the Dam: Intangible Loss and Damage to the Magar Indigenous Communities in Nepal 2025
- CEDAW General Recommendation 39 on the Rights of Indigenous Women and Girls (2022)- translation in Nepali
- Exploring Sustainability in Trophy Hunting Practices at Dhorpatan Hunting Reserve, Nepal: A Balancing Act? (2024)
- आदिवासी महिला, किशोरी र आदिवासी अपाङ्गता भएका महिलाहरू सम्बन्धी सीड नीतिको संक्षिप्तीकरण (2023)
- Perspectives of Hydropower Affected Indigenous Women on the Climate Crisis in Bhimad Municipality and Rishing Rural Municipality of Tanahu District, Nepal (November 2023)
- Assessing Gender Impacts of Proposed Iron Mining in Jhumlawang, Bhume Rural Municipality-3, East Rukum: A Technical Survey of Indigenous Magar and Dalit Women's Perpectives (2024)

- Is Nepal's Protected Area System Recognizing the Indigenous Peoples and Indigenous Women? Review Report on the legislation of the Protected Area System in Nepal (Refugia Indigenous peoples/ women in the protected area system)

- Baseline Report for Addressing Collective Land in Relation to Land-for-Land compensation for Land submerged Affecting Indigenous Peoples Impacted and Victimized by the Tanahu Hydro power Project (2025)

- Aspiration and Realities to imagine Violence-free Lives for Indigenous Women and Indigenous Women with Disabilities: An initial Step towards it (2021)

- Perception of Indigenous Bote and Tharus on Existing Conservation Approaches in Paithani Village of Chitwan National Park and Buffer Zone -Chitwan, Nepal (2024)

- Perception of Indigenous Peoples on Existing Conservation Approaches in Barahakshetra Municipality -11, Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve, Nepal (2024)

- Indigenous Rights in Nepal's Protected Areas: Policy Analysis of the National Parks and Wildlife Conservation Act

- Assessing Socio-Economic, Education, and Perception of Indigenous Peoples and Local Communities in and around Dhorpatan Hunting Reserve, Nepal